

China Macro Tracker

Engagement continues

- ◆ China and the EU set up workstreams to discuss areas of disagreement, with an October deadline set for tangible results
- ◆ Industrial profits softened, with mixed industry results: energy and AI sectors outperformed, but downstream faces pressure
- ◆ Year 3 of LG debt swap: audit flags questionable cases; NDRC reportedly discourages LGFVs from high-yield offshore borrowing

EU-China relations: doors remain open, but tensions are present

Just as China-US relations are showing signs of stabilising, the external narrative is starting to shift: China-EU tensions look more prone to escalation. The EU is pressing ahead with a clearer “de-risking” agenda and, with the proposed EU Industrial Accelerator Act, is signalling a more assertive push to expand made-in-EU manufacturing capacity. China’s exports to the bloc are primarily intermediate goods (40%) – largely supply chain trade, followed by capital goods (28%) and consumer goods (25%). Since 2023, the EU has launched trade remedy measures against made-in-China chemicals, steel, machinery and electrical equipment, and electric vehicles (Chart 1), and may expand its measures. In practice, the interaction is starting to look familiar: as with earlier episodes of China-US trade frictions, a sequence of targeted measures could begin to compound, broadening from specific sectors into wider questions of industrial policy and supply-chain security, and could take time to settle into a more predictable equilibrium.

For now, both sides remain in negotiations, and there’s still scope for pragmatic compromise given the depth of trade and investment linkages. On 29 June, China’s Commerce Minister Wang Wentao and the EU Trade Commissioner Maroš Šefčovič issued a Joint Statement outlining four workstreams (trade and investment, export controls, intellectual property rights and WTO reform) to continue dialogue. A follow-up minister-level meeting is set for the Autumn, with the EU Trade Commissioner later stating that there was an October deadline to reach “tangible results” (Reuters, 30 June).

But it’s worth being realistic about the complexity: the issues at stake go beyond tariffs into subsidies, standards, procurement and strategic technologies – which tend to be areas where “technical” disputes can quickly become political. A rockier relationship would not only affect China and the EU, but may also impact the Asia region more broadly (see [Regional implications of China-EU trade talks](#), 30 June).

China is unlikely to step back if tensions escalate, having expanded its countermeasures through initiatives such as the recent Supply Chain Security Act ([China macro tracker](#), 9 April) and the ODI regulation taking effect on 1 July. While negotiations may continue, the risk of tit-for-tat escalation cannot be fully discounted.

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Industrial profits: Energy, AI sectors outperformed, while downstream pressure lingered

China's industrial profits growth slowed to 21.1% y-o-y, despite a lower base, suggesting a slowdown in momentum. The bifurcation in results continued with upstream sectors (energy and non-ferrous metals) and some industries benefiting from global AI-related demand still outperforming. Going forward, profitability in oil-related upstream sectors may start to moderate following the easing of Middle East tensions and gradual resumption in global energy supply, though robust worldwide AI capital expenditure is expected to continue, supporting margins in the electronics sector. Excluding these sectors, performance across other industries—mainly midstream and downstream—worsened, with the drag increasing to 5.5ppt in Jan-May from 4.8ppt in Jan-Apr.

Rising energy costs have increased input-cost pressure across downstream sectors, whose output prices have stayed muted, resulting in margin compression. In particular, y-o-y profits declined by c11% in garments & apparel, c19% in leather and fur-related products, and c1% in rubber & plastics, weighing on profitability (chart 4). Cost pressures are likely to ease, though still tepid domestic end-demand remains a constraint for profit revival. Relatedly, [China's cautious consumer](#) (22 May) has meant lackluster performance in related categories. Y-o-y profits in furniture, sports and recreational products and autos fell c58%, c7% and 20% in the first five months of this year.

Meanwhile, weakness in property and infrastructure investment intensified since the start of Q2, contributing to a 1.2ppt drag on headline profit growth in Jan-May from ferrous metals and non-metal minerals. Going forward, we think a re-acceleration in government bond issuance and faster deployment of the RMB800bn of new policy-based financing tools should help infrastructure and construction activities, although property investment is likely to remain a drag. The recent implementation of cuts to VAT export rebates for solar and batteries since April likely also added pressure on profits in electrical machinery, where y-t-d profits fell 14% y-o-y.

Local government debt: de-risking agenda still strong; cases of data manipulation found

Local government fiscal constraints may continue to weigh on investment in the near term as an emphasis on addressing debt risk continues. However, with domestic growth showing signs of increased pressure, a policy pivot towards accelerated deployment of support is likely.

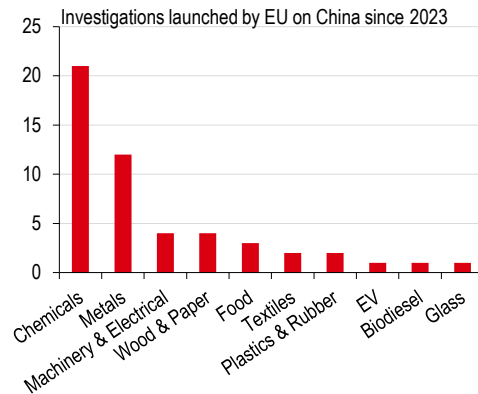
As of end-H1, over RMB2trn of local government refinancing bonds have already been issued, representing 73% of the annual quota (RMB2.8trn), showing clearly front-loaded issuance. Progress was also made in 2025, with over 82% of local government financing vehicles (LGFVs) having exited. Our estimates also suggest LGFV debt as a share of GDP edged down slightly to 46.8% in 2025 from 47.2% in 2024 (chart 5). Meanwhile, funding for projects has taken a step back. At end June, the pace of special local government bond issuance remains at a softer pace compared to 2025 levels, reaching 47% of the annual quota (chart 6).

China's National Audit Office flagged dubious cases in local debt resolution efforts, noting that 6% of LGFVs in spot checks falsified data to exit the list, while some localities added new hidden debt via SOEs and artificially lowered existing debt through loan substitutions and system data deletions (NAO, 24 June). Bloomberg (30 June) reported that the NDRC is discouraging LGFVs from issuing high-yield offshore debt, underscoring Beijing's concern that some local governments may be delaying clean-up efforts and masking underlying risks.

Softer local fiscal revenues remain a constraint for de-risking. The property downturn has meant land sales revenue was down 28.7% y-o-y in Jan-May. While Beijing is encouraging local governments to monetise and revitalise existing assets, helping lift non-tax revenues by 2.2% y-o-y ytd in May, more needs to be done. Looking ahead, faster fiscal reform, particularly to better align central-local expenditure responsibilities with revenue assignments, and to strengthen local fiscal revenue by broadening the consumption tax and allowing local governments to share in the revenues will help (see [China NPC Budget](#), 15 March).

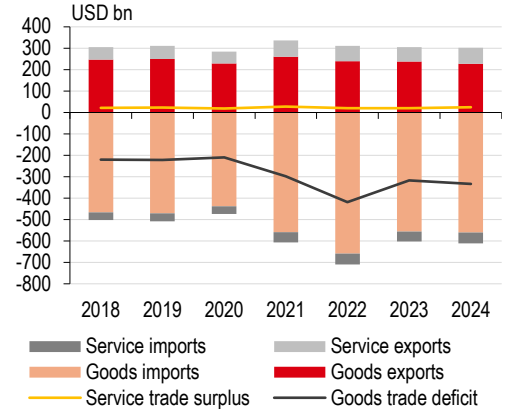
Charts of the week

1. The EU has expanded its trade remedy measures against China



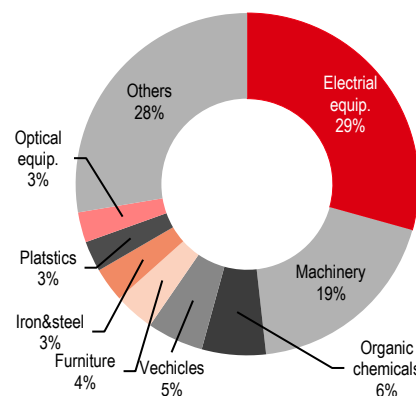
Source: China trade remedies information, HSBC; Note: as of 29 June.

2. EU trade with China has seen a larger goods deficit in recent years



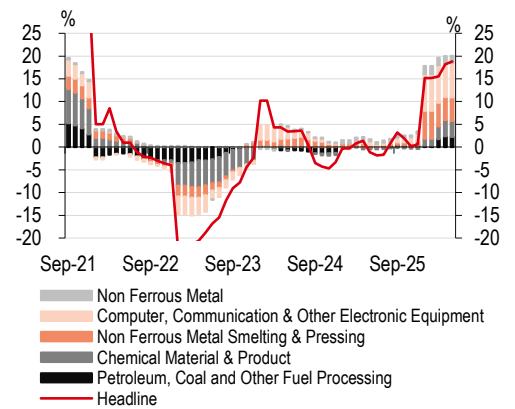
Source: UN Comtrade, HSBC

3. Key EU imports from mainland China



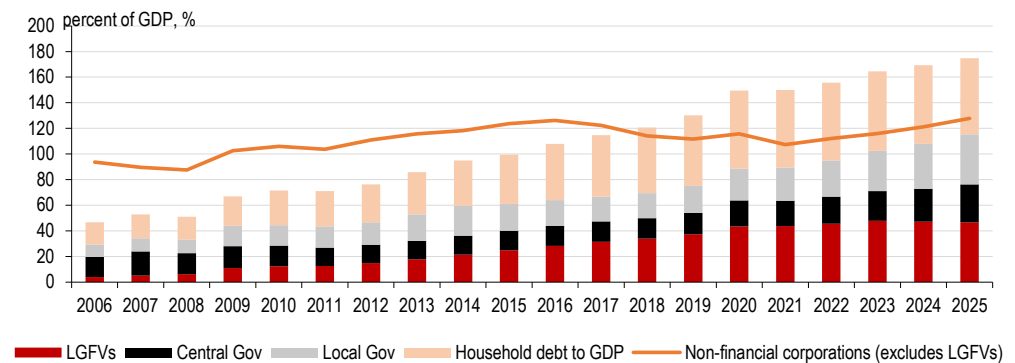
Source: CEIC, HSBC

4. Profits remained concentrated in energy and AI-related sectors



Source: CEIC, HSBC

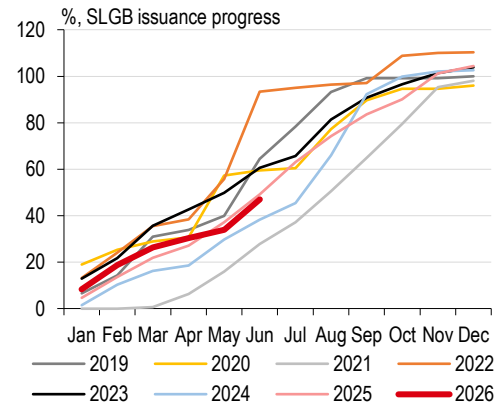
5. LGFV debt as a share of GDP edged down slightly



Source: CNBS, HSBC estimates; Note: For LGFV debt, we estimate it as the sum of the interest-bearing liabilities of LGFVs that have issued LGFV bonds.

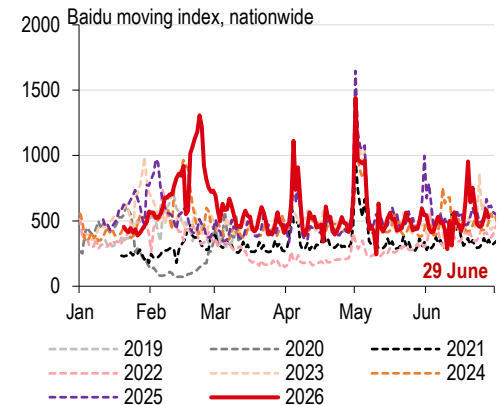
Economic activity

6. LGSB issuance can be stepped up to support infrastructure investment



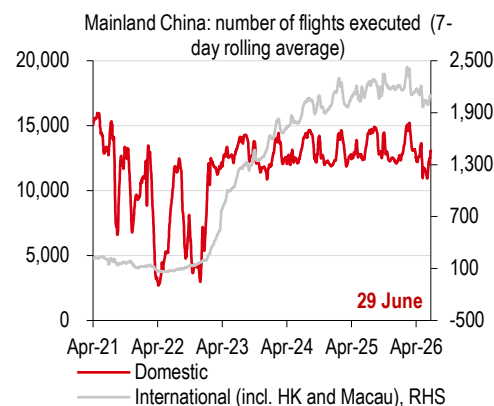
Source: Wind, HSBC; Note: Data as of 30 June.

7. Cross-city travel remained elevated



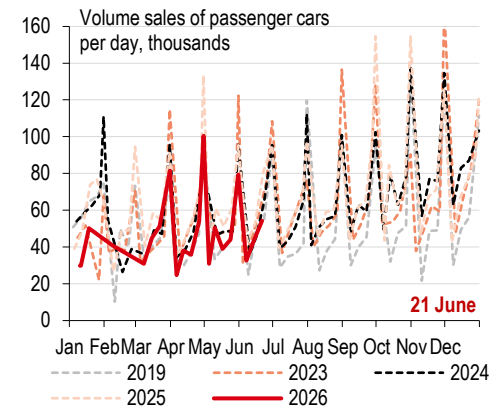
Source: Baidu Index, HSBC

8. The number of domestic flights moved up



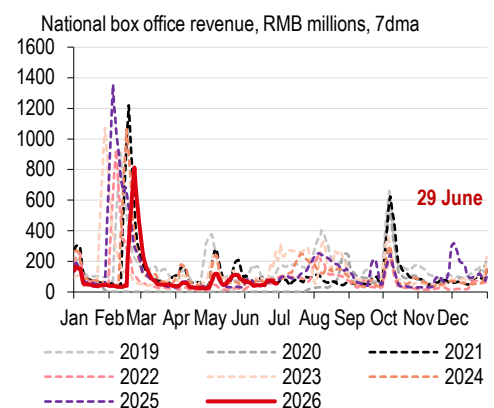
Source: Wind, HSBC

9. Car sales edged down in June in year-on-year terms



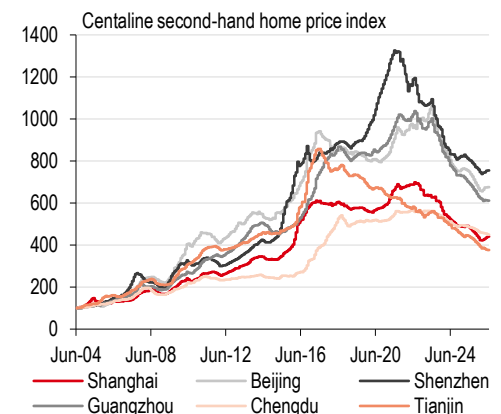
Source: Wind, HSBC

10. National box office revenues edged down



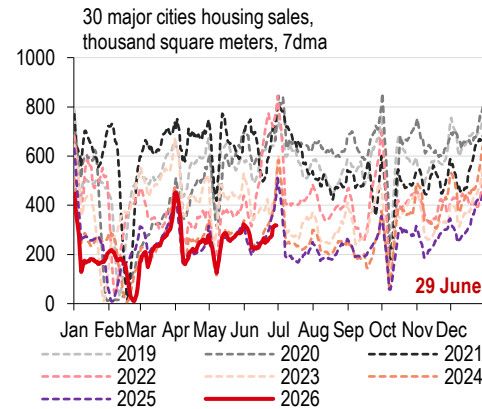
Source: Wind, HSBC

11. Housing prices in tier-1 cities edged up



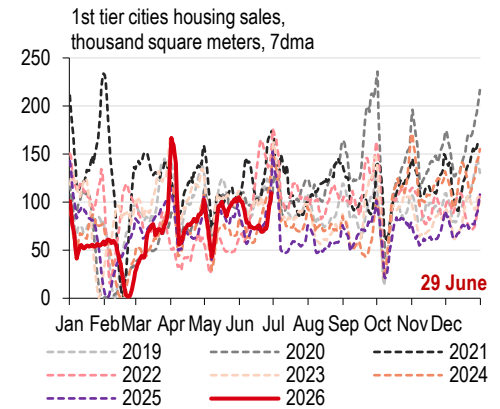
Source: Bloomberg, HSBC; Note: as of 30 June.

12. New home sales edged up seasonally



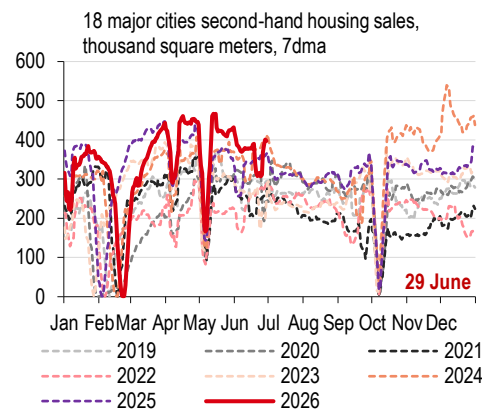
Source: Wind, HSBC

13. New home sales in Tier-1 cities remained higher y-o-y



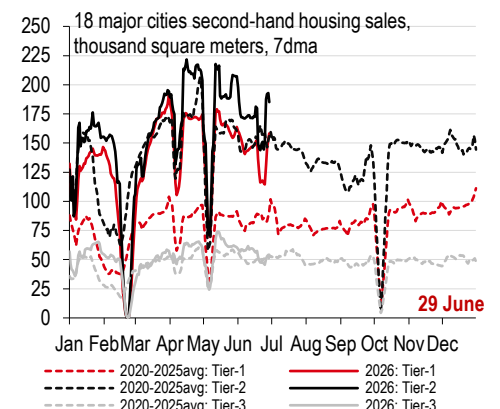
Source: Wind, HSBC

14. Second-hand home sales in 18 major cities rose seasonally



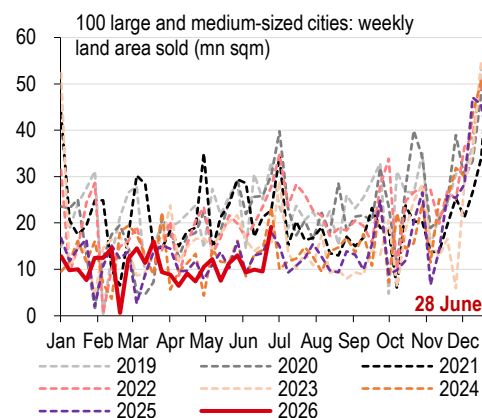
Source: Wind, HSBC

15. Transactions in second-hand homes in Tier-2 cities remained higher y-o-y



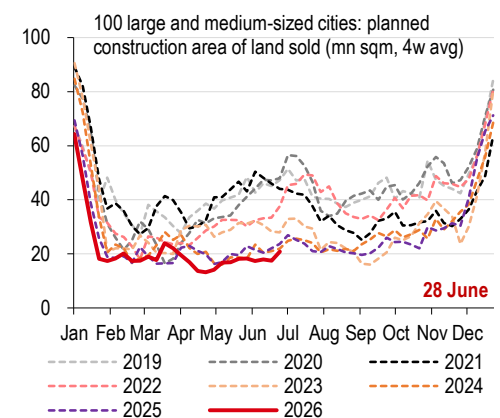
Source: Wind, HSBC

16. Land sales edged up



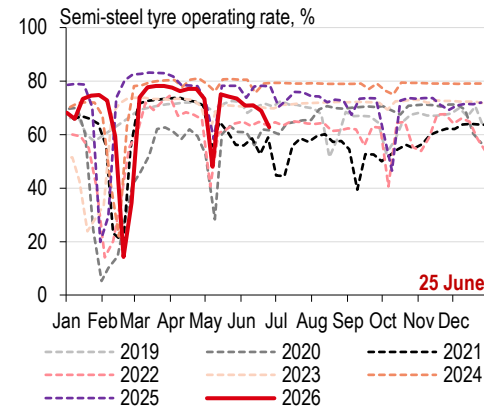
Source: Wind, HSBC

17. Planned construction area of land sold edged up



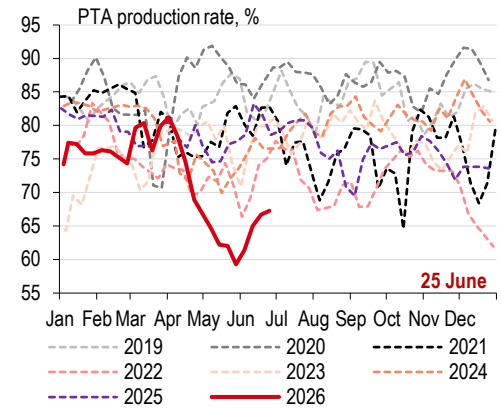
Source: Wind, HSBC

18. The semi-steel tyre operating rate edged down



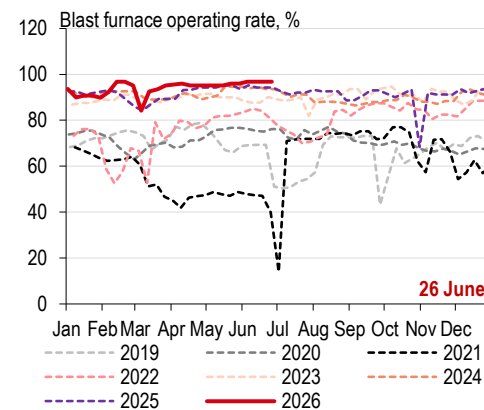
Source: Wind, HSBC

19. The production rate in the chemical sector picked up



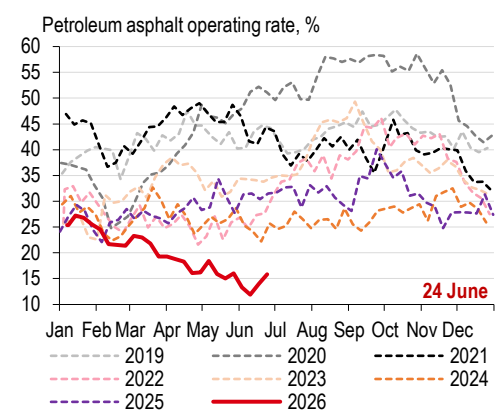
Source: Wind, HSBC

20. The blast furnace operating rate remained above historical levels



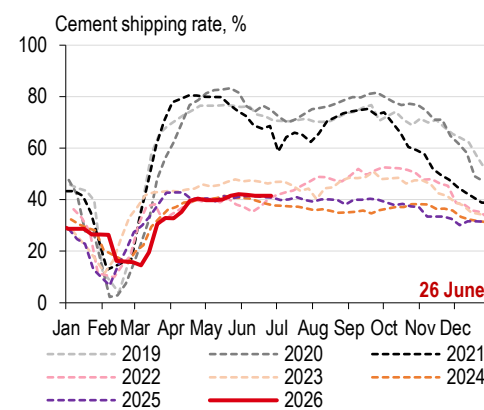
Source: Wind, HSBC

21. The petroleum asphalt operating rate ticked up



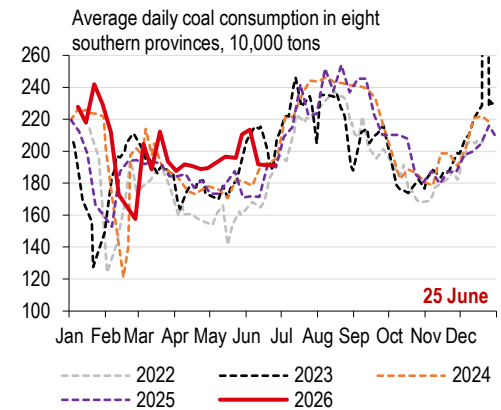
Source: Wind, HSBC

22. The cement shipping rate steadied



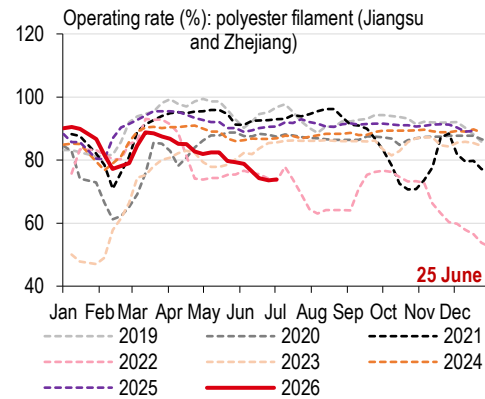
Source: Wind, HSBC

23. Coal consumption for eight major provinces edged down

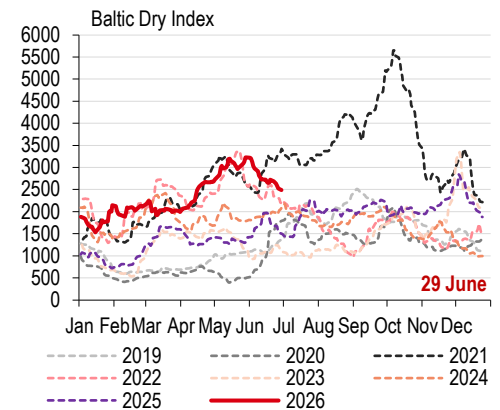


Source: Wind, HSBC

24. The operating rate of polyester filaments eased further

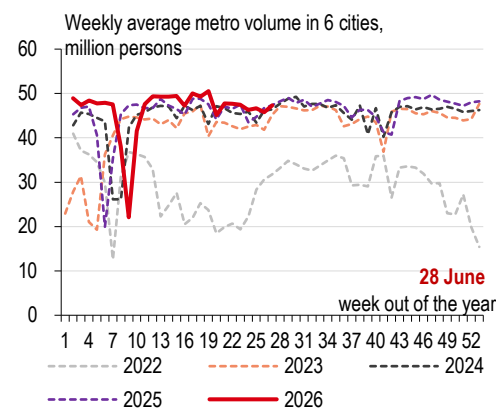


25. The Baltic Dry Index edged down

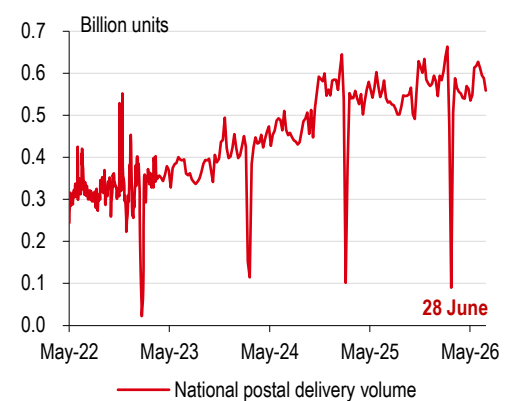


Travel and logistics

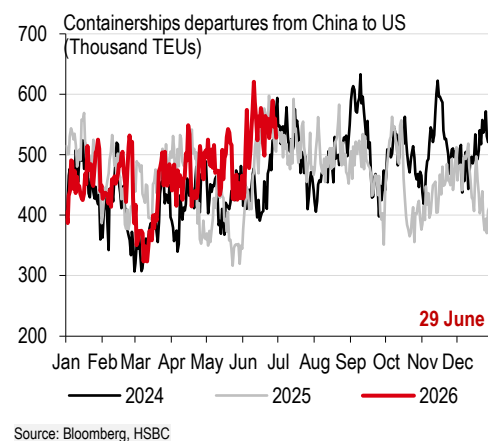
26. Metro volumes in large cities edged up



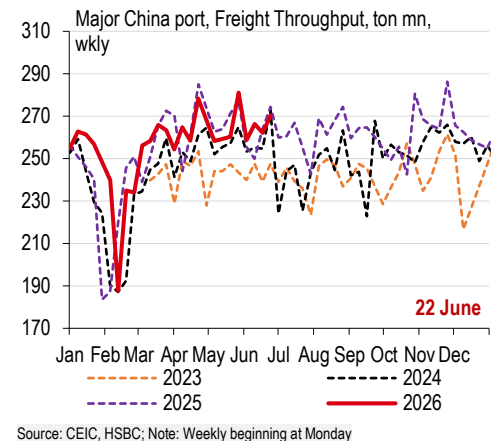
27. Postal delivery volumes edged down



28. Container exports from China to the US edged down

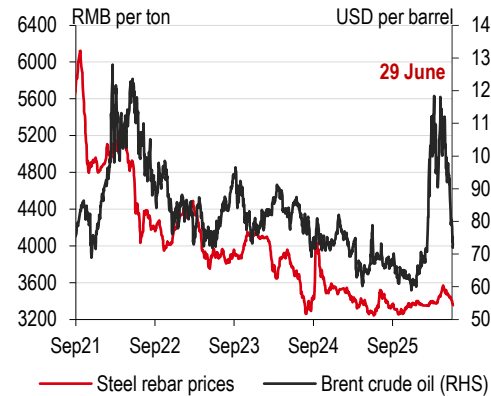


29. China's major ports' freight throughput edged up



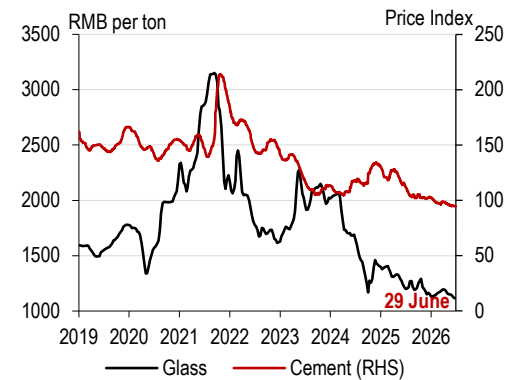
Inflation and policies

30. Crude oil prices fell as the US and Iran reached a deal



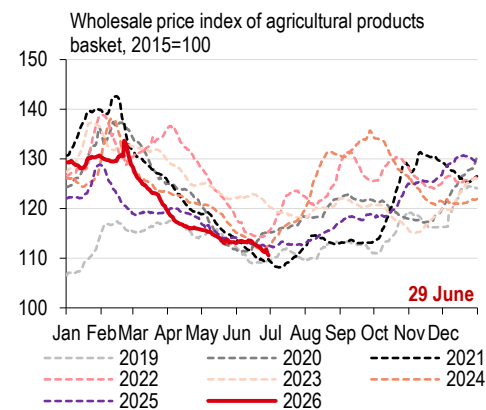
Source: Wind, HSBC

31. Cement prices and glass prices both edged down



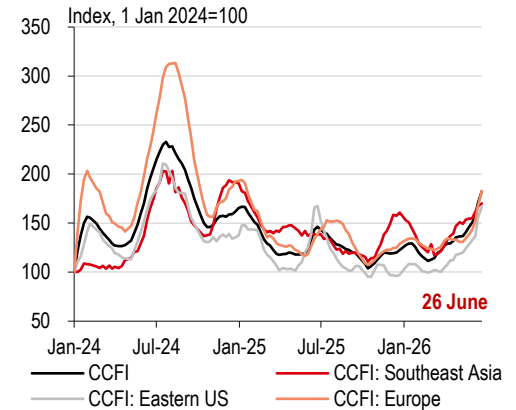
Source: Wind, HSBC

32. Agricultural product prices eased seasonally



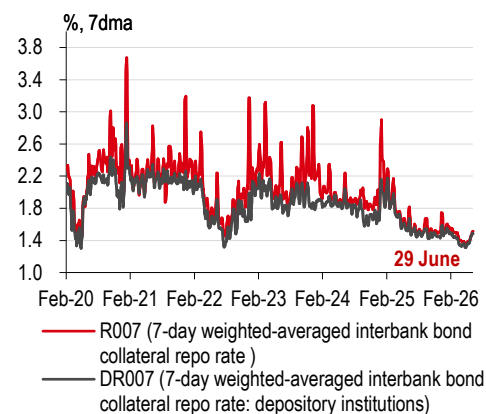
Source: Wind, HSBC

33. Container shipping costs on China-Southeast Asia route edged up



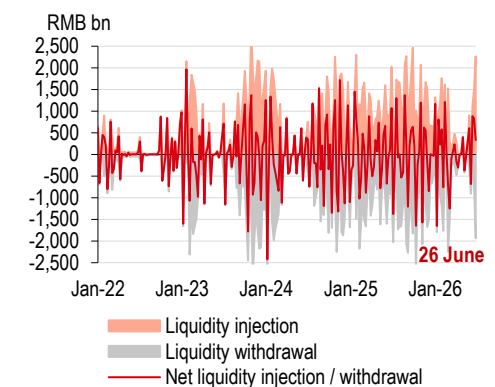
Source: Wind, HSBC

34. Interbank rates edged up



Source: Wind, HSBC

35. The PBOC made net injections through OMOs last week



Source: Wind, HSBC

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